

MANDAR DEODHAR

turning POINT

Michael Jackson's concert caused a big loss, but made them financially careful

biggest OBSTACLE

Convincing sceptics that parties needed precise planning by professionals

on their GROWTH

They used the contacts they had built in their heady nightclubbing days

JOSEPH, SARKARI AND TIMMINS AT THEIR MUMBAI OFFICE

SABBAS JOSEPH, 46 VIRAF SARKARI, 45 ANDRE TIMMINS, 44

CO-FOUNDERS, WIZCRAFT ENTERTAINMENT PROFESSIONALS
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1988 Rs 7,500
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 200 crore

THREE'S A PARTY

Can anyone be paid to party? You would think not. But if someone pays you the first time to make a nightclub rock, chances are your career choice has already been made. And if your first business venture—Mumbai's first non-five-star hotel disco, Zanadu, in 1986—attains a near iconic status, you know that entertainment is your adrenaline. It is not surprising then that most middle-aged Mumbaikars are yet to see anything remotely similar even after two decades. Once night manager Viraf Sarkari, DJ Andre Timmins and journalist Sabbas Joseph put their heads together, they realised that they could make a flourishing industry out of partying and in 1988 created entertainment company Wizcraft, with a capital of just Rs 7,500. Recalls Sarkari: "We re-

alised there were lots of rich people out there who were willing to pay us to organise their parties and weddings. Soon enough, corporates were calling us to handle their events and the biggest contacts came from the network we had formed at the nightclubs."

In time, they got into everything, managing nightclubs to organising dance competitions. Some of the contestants of their first All India Dance Championship included the director siblings Farah and Sajid Khan as well as actor Arshad Warsi. Through the years, the company has nurtured these relationships, so it is not surprising that almost all of Bollywood attends its flagship event—the International Indian Film Academy Awards (IIFA), which has taken desi glamour to the diaspora. Says Sarkari: "We be-